injustice, wickedness and cruelty'. Indeed, this Western vilification of the Jagannath cult began long before the colonial era, as that marvellous portmanteau of Anglo-Indianised words *Hobson-Jobson* demonstrates. *Hobson-Jobson* provides a dozen lurid accounts of devotees hurling themselves under the wheels of the Jagannath chariots, beginning with that of the Italian friar Odorico of Pordenone, who stopped at Puri in 1319 on his way to Sumatra and China and who noted that 'many pilgrims who have come to this feast cast themselves under the chariot, so that its wheels may go over them, saying that they desire to die for the god'.[1] Over the next five centuries other European travellers would give similar accounts.

In 1803 the East India Company (EICo) drove out the occupying Marathas and installed a British Commissioner in Puri, Andrew Stirling, who soon afterwards declared that as far as he could ascertain these ritual suicides had ended some time ago: 'That excess of fanaticism which formerly prompted the pilgrims to court death by throwing themselves in crowds under the wheels of the car of Jagannath has happily long ceased to actuate the worshippers of the present day.'[2] Over the course of four years' service he took part in several *ratha yatra* processions but witnessed only three fatalities, one of which was accidental.